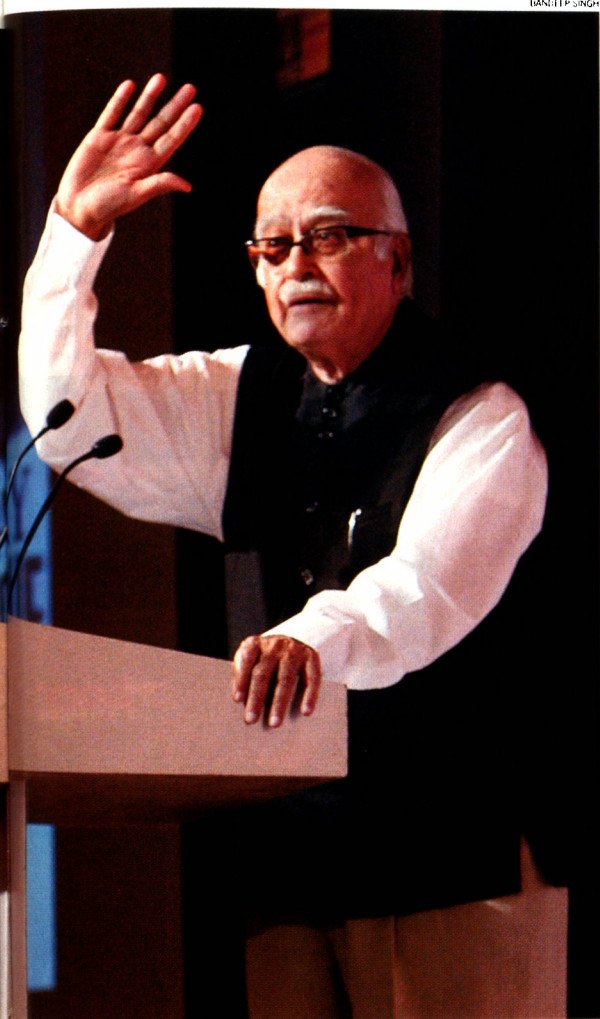




MANUELL SINGH

NDA's common minimum programme, we did not include some of the items we were very particular about. If our party strength has increased from two to 190, one major factor was our campaign against pseudo-secularism. Crores of people of this country regard a particular place as Ram Janmabhoomi, the birth place of Rama, and if they want to construct a temple there, what's wrong? Ayodhya brought us to power. But coalition politics has its compulsions. A coalition can be formed only when there is an agreed programme. In agreeing to that programme, we left aside Ayodhya, our desire to have Article 370 scrapped, and our demand for a uniform civil code in the country.

Through a process of dialogue and persuasion, the allies agreed to our commitment to India as a nuclear weapon power. When they agreed we added that to our common minimum programme and within two months had the Pokhran II explosion. But they (Congress) have not even mentioned the nuclear treaty in their common minimum programme. And the prime minister goes on saying, the deal is non-negotiable. If the Left doesn't agree with it, he says in a newspaper interview, let them go. This is not coalition dharma. When a majority of MPs are not in favour, why are you pursuing it?

Even on national security, our approach is—let the terrorists know that this is the leadership whose attitude towards terrorism is of zero tolerance. The Agra Summit collapsed because we refused to succumb to Musharraf. He didn't want to include his commitment to ending cross-border terrorism in the joint statement. I was criticised for that though it was a decision taken by the entire cabinet on security.

BJP represents the future of India whereas the Congress, which was once a common platform of great national leaders, represents much of what has gone wrong in India's recent past. In leadership qualities IQ may be important but EQ i.e. emotional quotient is even more important. And still more important are the moral quotient and spiritual quotient. It is in this respect that there is a difference between the leadership of the Congress and the leadership of the BJP.

DISCUSSION

Q. In the BJP there is a Double A dynasty—Atal and Advani. During the past 30 years, the party could not think beyond the two.

Advani: In our party there isn't any kind of dictatorship. We have interaction with all and if the party feels that Advani has done something wrong, Advani has to pay for it and he has paid for it.

Q. What would you protect—democracy or secularism—when a contradiction occurs like it did in Gujarat?

Advani: There is no contradiction. I remember understanding the meaning of secularism from Golwalkar. He said Indian polity has never accepted theocracy and that it was ironical that the government, without much thought, has accepted the symbol of Ashoka's Buddhist rule as a national symbol. I am of the view, that criticising the emblem is wrong. Once having accepted *Jan gan man* as the national anthem, there should be no debate on whether it should

have been *Vandematram*.

Secularism is part of our structure, it comes naturally to us.

Q. What is the BJP's appeal for young Indians who are educated, informed and smart?

Advani: My biggest complaint against the Congress is that as far as security is concerned, the party interest matters more than national interest. The government refuses to honour the Supreme Court verdict on Afzal Guru. Votebank politics has distorted politics. The youth

can contribute a lot here.

Q. During the Kandahar hijack, militants were released. Do you really mean to fight terrorists or is it just an electoral strategy?

Advani: Agra failed because we intended to fight terrorists. As for the hijack, I had the limitation of being part of the government. It was felt by various parties that the passengers should be rescued.

Full speech and debate at:

<http://www.indiatodayconclave.com>

